

Harvard University: Department of Economics
Economics 970
Labor Economics: Methods and Perspectives

Instructor: Jesse D. Meredith

Time: 4:30-5:45 Mondays and Wednesdays

Location: Sever Hall 101

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Office Hours: By Appointment. To schedule, see my Booking page at

<https://outlook.office.com/bookwithme/user/51e417f890844a119ccd4fea37a71a5c@fas.harvard.edu?anonymous&ep=plink>

If none of those openings work for you, please email me. The location will be determined on a case-by-case basis. If you have difficulties with the link or cannot attend any of the usual slots, please feel free to email me to schedule an alternate time.

Course Description

This course will build students' understanding of both the content and conduct of labor economics research. By the end of the course, students will be familiar with contemporary debates in the field and the research methods used to address them.

Topics to be covered include, but are not limited to:

- How does employment respond to changes in the minimum wage? If there are responses, how do they persist over time?
- How might Artificial Intelligence and Large Language Models affect human capital development and the college wage premium?
- How do we tell if immigration affects the employment or wages of already-present workers?
- How do we distinguish wage differentials arising from factors related to productivity (education, experience, etc.) from other factors?

Attention will also be paid to building skills useful beyond this course, including data analysis, identifying the strengths and limitations of existing work, and communicating results in a non-technical fashion.

Learning Objectives

This course is intended to help students become effective consumers and producers of economics research, both in future courses and in eventual employment.

- Identifying the comparisons at the core of most empirical labor economics papers.
- Familiarity with how advanced econometric techniques, such as instrumental variables and difference-in-differences, are used in practice.
- Describing a paper's methods and results to both technical and non-technical audiences.
- Discuss the limitations of a paper's causal identification strategy and its generalizability into other settings.
- Distinguish between statistical and practical significance.
- Understand and describe the questions on a topic that a given paper cannot address.

These lessons will be imparted through classroom discussion and through designing and implementing a research project.

Prerequisites

Students are required to have taken Principals of Economics (EC 10ab), Intermediate Microeconomics (EC 1010a/1011a), and [Introduction to Quantitative Methods for Economics](#) (STAT 104) or an equivalent course. Having taken an econometrics class such as EC1123 or EC 1126 will be useful but is not necessary.

Accommodations for students with disabilities

Harvard University values inclusive excellence and providing equal educational opportunities for all students. Our goal is to remove barriers for disabled students related to inaccessible elements of instruction or design in this course. If reasonable accommodations are necessary to provide access, please contact the [Disability Access Office \(DAO\)](#). Accommodations do not alter fundamental requirements of the course and are not retroactive. Students should request accommodations as early as possible, since they may take time to implement. Students should notify DAO at any time during the semester if adjustments to their communicated accommodation plan are needed.

Note on Mental and Holistic Health

It is okay not to be okay, and perfectly normal to need and ask for help. Student life at Harvard in our polarized, digital age can exacerbate stress, anxiety, worry and concern; thankfully, there are resources available to help invest in mental and holistic health. I would encourage you to consider reaching out to your Resident Dean, to [Counseling and Mental Health Services](#), and/or to the [Harvard Chaplains](#) for help or a listening ear if you are ever feeling overwhelmed, distressed, down, or burdened this semester.

Life throws us curveballs; please feel free to reach out if something comes up that is getting in the way of academic progress in this class.

Assignments & Grading

For all assignments with length requirements, they should be written in twelve-point font and double-spaced.

- Final Paper (45%):
 - List of ideas (2.5%): A list of research ideas to be discussed with the instructor. A high-quality submission would reference a specific question that the project would answer and describe what data, if any, would be required.
 - Research Pitch (5%): A brief document outlining the intended research project, including discussion of relevant prior work, a detailed description of the research project, and a list of any data sets required for the project.
 - Full Draft: (12.5%): A complete draft of the paper, on which the instructor will provide feedback and comments.
 - Final Submission (25%): A research paper on the topic of your choice, expected to be between 15-18 pages.
- Two Response Papers (2.5% each): Brief (3-4 page) papers based on a given prompt.
- Literature Review (7.5%): A Medium-Length (~5 page) paper summarizing the literature on a topic.
- Referee Report (2.5%): A brief (2-3 page) paper in which you will evaluate an article and its place in the literature. A successful report will summarize the work, describe how it

relates to other work, outline its key results, and summarize its strengths and shortcomings. More details will be given in the assignment handout

- Class participation (10%): This is a discussion-based class, and regular participation is crucial for both learning and evaluation. Attendance is mandatory, and students should come into each session prepared to discuss the reading.
- Class preparation (5%): For each class, there will be a few brief questions on Canvas to answer. These responses will be evaluated based on effort and completion. These assignments are meant to take less than 20 minutes each once you have read the associated paper. These questions will help you prepare to discuss the paper in class. They are due at **6pm** the day before each class session.
- Empirical Exercise (10%): This moderate length (~5 page) assignment will involve analyzing data and interpreting the results. More details will be available on the assignment handout.
- Policy Memo (5%): This moderate length (~5 page) assignment will demonstrate your ability to summarize the results of economics research for non-technical audiences. Details will be available on the assignment handout.
- Stata/R Problem Sets (10%): These four problem sets evaluate your ability to work with data in a practical setting. They are due on February 13, February 27, March 13, and April 3.

Course Policies

- AI: In this class, you will be asked to use AI on specific assignments. In these assignments, you will be given specific guidelines on how to use AI and will be required to include a log of all prompts and results with your assignment submission. **Use of AI in any other fashion, including in the Stata/R PS, is strictly prohibited.** Any violation of this policy will be treated as academic dishonesty and referred to the Honor Council.
- Laptops in the classroom: Laptops are permitted. However, I would direct your attention to Carter, Greenberg, and Walker's (2017) study, which found that classes randomly assigned to forbid laptops had higher exam scores than classes assigned to allow laptops.¹ Harvard's Bok Center for Teaching and Learning also recommends limiting use of laptops in the classroom.² It will be possible to fully participate in the course without having a laptop in the classroom.
- Extensions & Late work: In general, late work will be deducted one step grade for each day or part thereof that it is late (e.g., A to A-, C+ to C). In exceptional circumstances, an extension may be granted. The extension must be requested at least 24 hours before the due date. Note that the deadline for the final research paper (May 6) is a course-wide deadline. I cannot give extensions on it.
- Statement on Academic Honesty: Discussing ideas and work-in-progress with others is an important and desirable part of the research process, but in the end, a student's assignment must be his or her own effort, written by the student, and ultimately based on his or her own thinking. All written assignments must use appropriate citation practices.

¹ Carter, S. P., Greenberg, K., & Walker, M. S. (2017). The impact of computer usage on academic performance: Evidence from a randomized trial at the United States Military Academy. *Economics of Education Review*, 56, 118–132. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.econedurev.2016.12.005>

² <https://bokcenter.harvard.edu/technology-policies>

For questions about Harvard's stance on academic honesty, consult the Academic Information section in the Harvard College Handbook for Students.

Key Dates

February 2	Final paper ideas due
February 9	Response paper 1 due
February 13	Stata/R problem set 1 due
February 18	Research pitch due
February 27	Stata/R problem set 2 due
March 2	Referee report due
March 9	Literature Review Due
March 13	Stata/R problem set 3 due
March 23	Response paper 2 due
March 30	Empirical exercise due
April 1	AI check due
April 3	Stata/R problem set 4 due
April 13	Policy memo due
April 22	Full draft of paper due
May 6	Final paper due

Course Schedule:

Note that this schedule is tentative and subject to change. The most up-to-date version is available on the course's Canvas site.

- January 26: Introductions
 - Readings: None
- January 28: Minimum Wage 1
 - Readings:
 - Writing Economics Guide Sections 1-2.
 - Card, D., & Krueger, A. B. (1994). Minimum wages and employment: a case study of the fast-food industry in New Jersey and Pennsylvania. *The American Economic Review*, 84(4), 772–793.
- February 2: Minimum Wage 2
 - **List of final paper ideas due.**
 - Reading: Cengiz, D., Dube, A., Lindner, A., & Zipperer, B. (2019). The Effect of Minimum Wages on Low-Wage Jobs. *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 134(3), 1405–1454. <https://doi.org/10.1093/qje/qjz014>
 - Writing Economics Guide Section 2
- February 4: Theory & Empirics 1
 - Reading: Boal, W. M., & Ransom, M. R. (1997). Monopsony in the Labor Market. *Journal of Economic Literature*, 35(1), 86–112.
- February 9: Minimum Wage 3
 - **Response Paper 1 Due**
 - Reading: Meer, Jonathan and West, Jeremy. (2016) “Effects of the Minimum Wage on Employment Dynamics.” *Journal of Human Resources*, 51(2), 500-522
- February 11: Minimum Wage 4

- **Note that the first Stata/R problem set is due the following Friday.**
- Readings:
 - Jardim, E., Long, M. C., Plotnick, R., van Inwegen, E., Vigdor, J., & Wething, H. (2022). Minimum-Wage Increases and Low-Wage Employment: Evidence from Seattle. *American Economic Journal. Economic Policy*, 14(2), 263–314. <https://doi.org/10.1257/pol.20180578>
- February 18: Discrimination 1
 - **Research Pitch Due**
 - Reading: Sections 1-3 of Blau, F. D., & Kahn, L. M. (2017). The gender wage gap: Extent, trends, and explanations. *Journal of Economic Literature*, 55(3), 789–865. <https://doi.org/10.1257/jel.20160995>
- February 23: Discrimination 2
 - Reading: Bertrand, M., & Mullainathan, S. (2004). Are Emily and Greg More Employable than Lakisha and Jamal? A Field Experiment on Labor Market Discrimination. *The American Economic Review*, 94(4), 991–1013. <https://doi.org/10.1257/0002828042002561>
- February 25: Theory & Empirics 2
 - **Note that the second Stata/R problem set is due the following Friday**
 - Readings:
 - Writing Economics Guide Section 4
 - Lang, K., & Lehmann, J.-Y. K. (2012). Racial Discrimination in the Labor Market: Theory and Empirics. *Journal of Economic Literature*, 50(4), 959–1006. <https://doi.org/10.1257/jel.50.4.959>
 - Focus on the theory section
- March 2: Discrimination 3
 - **Referee Report Due**
 - Reading: Goldin, C., & Rouse, C. (2000). Orchestrating Impartiality: The Impact of “Blind” Auditions on Female Musicians. *The American Economic Review*, 90(4), 715–741. <https://doi.org/10.1257/aer.90.4.715>
- March 4: Discrimination 4
 - Reading: Bütikofer, A., Jensen, S., & Salvanes, K. G. (2018). The role of parenthood on the gender gap among top earners. *European Economic Review*, 109, 103–123. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.eurocorev.2018.05.008>
- March 9: Immigration 1
 - **Literature Review Due**
 - Reading: Hanson, G. H. (2009). The Economic Consequences of the International Migration of Labor. *Annual Review of Economics*, 1(1), 179–207. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.economics.050708.143247>
- March 11: Immigration 2
 - **Note that the third Stata/R problem set is due the following Friday**
 - Readings:
 - Card, D. (1990). The Impact of the Mariel Boatlift on the Miami Labor Market. *Industrial & Labor Relations Review*, 43(2), 245. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2523702>
 - Borjas, G. J. (2016). *The Wage Impact of the Marielitos: Additional Evidence*. National Bureau of Economic Research Working Paper 21850.

- March 23: Immigration 3
 - **Response Paper 2 Due**
 - Reading: Peri, G., & Yasenov, V. (2019). The Labor Market Effects of a Refugee Wave: Synthetic Control Method Meets the Mariel Boatlift. *The Journal of Human Resources*, 54(2), 267–309. <https://doi.org/10.3368/jhr.54.2.0217.8561R1>
- March 25: Immigration 4
 - Reading: Bryan, G., & Morten, M. (2019). The aggregate productivity effects of internal migration: Evidence from Indonesia. *Journal of Political Economy*, 127(5), 2229–2268.
- March 30: Program Evaluation 1
 - **Empirical Exercise Due**
 - Autor, D. H., Duggan, M., Greenberg, K., & Lyle, D. S. (2016). The Impact of Disability Benefits on Labor Supply: Evidence from the VA's Disability Compensation Program. *American Economic Journal. Applied Economics*, 8(3), 31–68. <https://doi.org/10.1257/app.20150158>
- April 1: Program Evaluation 2
 - **AI Check Due**
 - **Note that the fourth Stata/R problem set is due the following Friday**
 - Reading: Muralidharan, K., and Singh, A. (2025) "Adapting for scale: Experimental Evidence on Technology-aided Instruction in India," *National Bureau of Economic Research Working Paper* 34205. <https://doi.org/10.3386/w34205>.
- April 6: Education & Human Capital 1
 - Reading: Ashworth, J., & Ransom, T. (2019). Has the college wage premium continued to rise? Evidence from multiple U.S. surveys. *Economics of Education Review*, 69, 149–154. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.econedurev.2019.02.003>
- April 8: Education & Human Capital 2
 - Reading: Becker, G. S. (1962). Investment in Human Capital: A Theoretical Analysis. *The Journal of Political Economy*, 70(5), 9–49. <https://doi.org/10.1086/258724>
- April 13: Education & Human Capital 3
 - **Policy Memo Due**
 - Moretti, E. (2004). Estimating the social return to higher education: Evidence from longitudinal and repeated cross-sectional data. *Journal of Econometrics*, 121(1), 175–212. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jeconom.2003.10.015>
- April 15: Education & Human Capital 4
 - Reading: Card, D., & DiNardo, J. E. (2002). Skill-Biased Technological Change and Rising Wage Inequality. *Journal of Labor Economics*, 20(4), 733–783. <https://doi.org/10.1086/342055>
- April 20: AI 1
 - Reading: Korinek, A. (2023). Generative AI for Economic Research: Use Cases and Implications for Economists. *Journal of Economic Literature*, 61(4), 1281–1317. <https://doi.org/10.1257/jel.20231736>
- April 22: AI 2
 - **Full Draft of Paper Due**

- Reading: Avitabile, A., Bartanen, B., & Kwok, A. (2025). Using Large Language Models to Analyze Preservice Teacher Feedback and Reflections during Clinical Teaching. EdWorkingPaper No. 25-1203. *Annenberg Institute for School Reform at Brown University*.
- April 27: AI 3
 - Reading: TBD
- April 29: AI 4
 - Reading: TBD
- May 6
 - **Final Paper Due**